

Brand orientation in the charity sector: A framework for discussion and research

Philippa Hankinson

University of Surrey Roehampton, 80 Roehampton Lane, London SW15 5SL, UK;
Tel: +44 (0)20 8392 3484; Fax: +44 (0)20 8392 3646; e-mail:
p.hankinson@roehampton.ac.uk

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Philippa Hankinson is a senior lecturer in marketing at the University of Surrey Roehampton with a special interest in brands and their management. Under her former name of Cowking, she has co-authored 'Branding in Practice' and 'The Reality of Global Brands', as well as writing several journal articles and conference research papers in the UK and USA. She was formerly Director of Research and Planning at Clarke Hooper Consulting. She has now extended her research focus into the charity sector where she acts as a brand consultant to several charity organisations.

ABSTRACT

Some charity organisations are turning to charity brand status, not only in terms of a name and logo but more importantly in terms of communicating value and meaning to their stakeholders. Brand orientation is described in this paper as the extent to which charity organisations regard themselves as brands, an indication of how much (or how little) organisations accept the theory and practice of branding. Through literature-based and field-based research, this paper examines the nature of brand orientation in the charity sector. A conceptual framework of brand orientation is proposed with antecedent factors which may augment or diminish levels of brand orientation and consequences which may follow its adoption. A number of research propositions are put

forward which constitute both a framework for discussion and a research agenda for the charity sector.

INTRODUCTION

Brands have long been an essential component of the for-profit, marketing discipline, driven primarily by a need to create and maintain a point of difference in an increasingly competitive environment. By contrast, very little scholarly activity has been devoted to the development and strategic use of brands in the charity sector in either the UK or the USA. Arguably, this has resulted from the greater complexity of charity brands as opposed to commercial brands,¹ difficulties in committing internal stakeholders to branding concepts,² the risk of being seen to be 'too commercial',³ or even 'immoral', (Sargeant).⁴

Nevertheless, many charity organisations are now turning to charity brand status, not only in terms of a name and logo but also in terms of communicating value and meaning which, in the USA, represents 6.4 per cent of GDP, and, in the UK, represents 4.0 per cent.⁵ Holistically, a brand may be described as the totality of perceptions and experiences surrounding a product, a service, an organisation or, indeed, a charity. Such perceptions and

experiences may be grouped according to two dimensions: the functional, what the brand does; and the symbolic, what the brand represents.⁶ Together, these dimensions constitute the brand personality, the essence of the brand. Brand orientation may be described as 'the extent to which the organisation regards itself as a brand'.⁷ It is a measure of how much (or how little) organisations accept the theory and practice of branding. Hence a brand-oriented organisation is one whose thinking and behaviours are consistent with the brand construct or the framework within which brands operate.

Through literature- and field-based research, this paper explores the domain and boundaries of brand orientation. It seeks to provide an operational definition of brand orientation whose constituent parts may be empirically tested and to develop a number of research propositions which may constitute a research agenda for the charity sector. In this way, the paper hopes to provide a foundation for the systematic development of brand orientation in the charity sector, thereby responding to the dearth of academic writing in this area and, in particular, to the challenges made on both sides of the Atlantic,^{8,9} of the need to develop a set of theories and a framework for discussion which will better equip the charity sector for the 21st century.

METHODOLOGY

The methodology draws on extant literature in brands and brand orientation and, in compliance with Hunt's view¹⁰ that theories should 'truly say something about the world', augments these with findings from individual, in-depth interviews. Fifteen in-depth interviews were, therefore, carried out with fundraising and/or communication directors whose decision-making remit included whether to 'brand'

their charity organisation or not. The sample represented key charity sectors in the UK,¹¹ namely medicine/health, general welfare, international aid, animal protection and environment. It was further categorised by size with (almost) equal representation of large charities, defined as those with an annual income of £50m or more; medium-sized charities, defined as those with an annual income of £5m and up to £50m; and small charities, defined as those with an annual income of less than £5m.

The sample may, therefore, be described as 'purposive',¹² ie representative of a wide range of experience and perspectives, and appropriate to theory building and the elicitation of constructs and research propositions.¹³

A topic guide was used to steer the overall interviewing process in line with an inductive research approach¹⁴ and qualitative research practices.¹⁵ However, as this was essentially elicitation research, a 'rolling approach' was used, consistent with qualitative research practice.¹⁶ This typically frees the researcher from the constraints of a pre-set topic guide by allowing emerging themes from earlier interviews to be fed into later interviews. Hence the basic topic guide included the following broad areas:

- to what extent do they perceive their charity organisation as a brand?
- how is this manifested in their thinking and behaviour?
- what factors augment or diminish this perception?
- what are the consequences of this perception?

Each in-depth interview typically lasted 45–60 minutes, was audio-taped and subsequently transcribed. Each transcript was then subject to detailed content analysis,¹⁷ in which common themes were iden-

tified. Fieldwork was carried out between March and June 1999.

Hence, the research methodology was designed to provide a synthesis of literature-based and field-based propositions in keeping with the traditions of Kohli and Jaworski¹⁸ and de Chernatony and Dall'Olmo Riley.¹⁹

LITERATURE REVIEW

A review of the literature on brands and brand orientation in the charity sector reveals a paucity of scholarly activity on brands until, perhaps, the last decade and, at the time of writing, none at all on brand orientation. This is surprising, given the fact that marketing ideas have been applied to the nonprofit sector for at least the last 30 years,^{20–22} and that brands and their management are an integral part of the marketing discipline. However, examples of marketing concepts and techniques as applied to the charity sector, do exist and include donor modelling studies,^{23–25} the nature of exchange,^{26,27} market orientation,^{28–30} relationship marketing,³¹ and cause-related marketing,^{32,33} all of which suggest that the charity sector may already benefit from ideas from neighbouring disciplines.

Recent brand-focused articles, however, bear witness to three core themes, derived principally from case study reports and brand practice papers. The three themes are as follows: 1) analysing the brand, 2) communicating the brand, and 3) using the brand as a strategic resource.

Understanding the brand

Case studies such as Crisis,³⁴ the Children's Society,³⁵ and Barnardo's³⁶ highlight the need for charities to develop and build attractive brand personalities for their organisations, both as a means of differentiation in an increasingly competitive environment and as a means of

building meaning into relationships with charity stakeholders. The trigger to a re-branding exercise was often a fundraising crisis when it was discovered that the 'old' brand personality no longer 'fitted' politically correct thinking, for instance the move from disabled to enabling charities, or when the existing charity brand personality no longer provided a satisfying relationship with stakeholders, for example, the metamorphosis of Greenpeace's 'blokes in boats' to a scientifically based, environmental charity with global responsibilities. These studies lend credence to the view that charity brands are not easily explained by definitions that focus on a name and logo alone,^{37,38} but require a more complex analysis that distinguishes between the functional attributes of the brands — its cause — and the symbolic values of the brand — its beliefs.³⁹

Communicating the brand

Tapp⁴⁰ raises the issue of 'soundbite fundraising' when brands are used to communicate complex messages, briefly and simply, capitalising on the a priori reputation or personality of the brand. Roberts-Wray⁴¹ emphasises the importance of choosing appropriate and contextually sensitive communication channels which are consistent with the brand reputation or personality. Telephone fundraising, for example, may be appropriate for the Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (RSPCA), with its brand reputation for direct action, but it would not be appropriate for Imperial Cancer Research Fund. Saxton⁴² argues that different messages should be used for different stakeholders, such as the press, volunteers, donors or politicians. The issue here, however, is to ensure that multiple messages still communicate the brand in a clear and consistent way so that the

integrity of the brand personality is maintained.

Using the brand as a strategic resource

There was little recognition in the literature of using brands as a strategic resource with some exceptions, for instance, Lindsay and Murphy's study⁴³ of charity brands to change public opinion and Tonkiss and Passey's study,⁴⁴ of brands to build donor trust. Yet this is an important area in the for-profit sector, as evidenced by the willingness of companies to offer hugely inflated prices in takeover battles for well-known brands. Nestle, for instance, paid £2.5bn in 1988 for Rowntree's tangible net assets which were worth around £300m at the time. The rationale behind such extraordinary valuations is the perception that successful brands are a company's lifeblood, their future source of income, and there is no reason to suppose that charity brands might not be used similarly.

The literature review has identified three key areas of brand research, although none is particularly well documented. It is perhaps indicative of the fact that too little attention has been given to the topic of brands and the branding process within the charity sector, lending additional support to Tapp's view⁴⁵ that 'charities are under-using one of their most powerful assets: their brands'.

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS

Charity managers were able to provide clear examples of how and in what circumstances they perceived their charity as a brand and, in so doing, helped develop the brand orientation construct more precisely. The same three themes emerged as from the academic literature, but in addition a fourth theme proved important to charity managers, that of managing the brand.

Understanding the brand

Most charity managers agreed that in perceiving their organisation as a brand, it was important to analyse how different stakeholders in the organisation understood the values it represented. Hence an important first step was to undertake a brand audit among its various stakeholders including employees, trustees, donors, non donors, journalists, government representatives and so on. Sometimes the audit revealed a 'confused' personality for the brand, with different stakeholders perceiving the brand in different ways. Hence, it was important for charity managers to agree a 'template' or common personality for the organisation which would reflect more accurately (and more consistently) its functional attributes, its charity cause and its symbolic values — those to which stakeholders might align their own values in mutually satisfying relationships.

Communicating the brand

Charity managers distinguished more clearly than is apparent from the literature review that brand communication comes in more than one guise. It may be visual, scripted or behavioural. Visual communicators, arguably the most highly developed form of brand communication, included name and logo, media coverage and websites. Scripted communicators included straplines such as 'tackling disadvantage by realising people's potential', used by Voluntary Service Overseas (VSO), while behavioural communicators provided opportunities to bring the charity's brand values 'alive'. For instance, the RSPCA may be seen to be behaving consistently with its cause and its symbolic values of being 'caring', 'responsible', 'authoritative' and 'effective', by pursuing those who perpetrate cruelty to animals, through the courts.

Using the brand as a strategic resource

Charity managers used their brands, strategically, as a shorthand communication of what the brand was, its cause, and what it represented, its values. This enabled charities to communicate large amounts of complex information, clearly and consistently. Most frequently, charities used their brands to: aid staff/volunteer recruitment; educate and, sometimes, to change public opinion; offer opportunities for conscientious consumption through cause-related marketing partnerships; lobby parliament on issues such as child abuse or environmental pollution; and build trust in the absence, sometimes, of more complete knowledge about the charity organisations. Charity brands were, therefore, being used by charity managers to fulfil a more extensive range of organisational objectives than was apparent from the academic literature, and arguably, in a more effective way than 'unbranded' charity organisations could hope to achieve.

Managing the brand actively and deliberately

This was an area that charity managers were only just beginning to address. They did not consider it a frontline responsibility, nor did they anticipate much support from within the charity organisation. Indeed, some reported that 'conservatism from the top' was a significant barrier to the introduction of new ideas and techniques, particularly by those from non-commercial backgrounds who perceived their role as guardians of the charity cause and its finances rather than marketers of a competitive product. As a result, some charity brands survived by default. On the other hand, several charity managers from the in-depth interviews did regard their organisations as brands and had been practising brand management skills, albeit

in a fragmented way, over a number of years. Nevertheless, they often felt isolated in their thinking and commitment to brand practices. They felt their efforts were being hampered by a lack of organisational responsibility for the brand, so that brand management was carried out piecemeal and without central co-ordination. Managing the brand actively and deliberately was a crucial step in co-ordinating brand activity for the charity and engaging others in that process.

DEVELOPING THE BRAND ORIENTATION CONSTRUCT

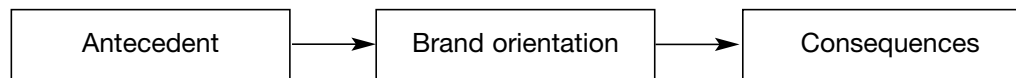
Drawing together the themes from the academic literature and the in-depth interviews which characterise the way in which brands are regarded in the charity sector, the following working definition of brand orientation is offered.

Brand orientation involves:

- an understanding of what the brand does and the values it represents
- communicating the charity brand to both external and internal audiences
- using the brand as a strategic resource
- managing the brand actively and deliberately.

It may be more useful to define brand orientation as a continuum rather than a dichotomous construct which implies either presence or absence. A consequence of this will be to facilitate measurement of the construct by allowing respondents to indicate the degree to which their charity is brand-oriented, rather than whether brand orientation exists or not. Furthermore, it may be useful to consider antecedents which may augment or diminish levels of brand orientation in charities, and consequences that may follow its adoption. Thus, in outline, the brand orientation construct

Figure 1 Outline model of brand orientation construct



includes the three steps shown in Figure 1. These are discussed below together with appropriate research propositions which may further the discussion of brand orientation in the charity sector.

RESEARCH PROPOSITIONS

Antecedents

Four factors consistently emerge from the literature and field interviews that seem to impact on levels of brand orientation in charities. These are:

- personal vision
- relevant educational and job experience with brands
- a supportive organisational culture and
- environmental factors that may influence organisational objectives.

Personal vision

The academic literature, mostly from outside the charity sector, emphasises the importance of personal vision in developing and implementing new ideas within organisations.^{46,47} Leadership studies^{48–50} also indicate the importance of commitment and, at times, a willingness to take risks in order to achieve acceptance of new ideas within a company. From the in-depth interviews, it was clear that often kick-starting a change of status from charity organisation to charity brand was a high-level appointment to a key post such as Fundraising Director, Communication Director, or, as in one case, Brand Director, of someone totally committed to transforming the organisation

into a brand. Hence the following research proposition may be formulated:

P₁ The greater the personal vision of key charity managers, the greater the degree of brand orientation in charity organisations.

Relevant educational and job experience with brands

Hankinson and Cowking⁵¹ report that brand managers are well educated and that some have management-related graduate qualifications such as an MBA. The in-depth interviews also indicated that those most committed to the brand construct had qualifications at undergraduate or postgraduate level in management- or marketing-related programmes. Almost certainly, these programmes would include courses in brands and their management. In addition, the field interviews also revealed that several charity managers in key positions had cut their branding teeth in the commercial sector. Hence, the following research propositions may be formulated:

P₂ The more relevant the educational achievement of charity managers, the greater the degree of brand orientation.

P₃ Senior management experience of brand orientation in the for-profit sector will increase brand orientation in the charity sector.

Supportive organisational culture

The academic literature, again mostly from

outside the charity sector, argues in favour of supportive organisational cultures to encourage the successful adoption of new ideas.^{52,53} Companies such as 3M and Microsoft 'allow' employees to experiment and sometimes to fail, in order to foster a climate of innovation and change. The depth interviews, however, suggested a more cautious culture in charity organisations which, in some cases, went so far as resistance to change. Brand knowledge and training, for instance, were not always considered a priority among charity trustees, whose power and influence would be crucial to the introduction of brand orientation. Hence, the following research proposition may be formulated:

P₄ Charities with supportive organisational cultures demonstrate higher levels of brand orientation than charities with more cautious cultures.

Environmental factors

The academic literature points to a range of factors which are shaping a new environment for charities to which brand orientation could offer a successful response.⁵⁴ Charitable giving, for instance, has changed over the last 20 years,⁵⁵ with fewer households giving to charities and younger households giving the least of all. The lottery has often been blamed for declining levels of charitable giving, although the evidence does not support this.^{56,57} Balabanis *et al.*,⁵⁸ report a significant increase in the use of a market orientation in the Top 200 UK charities over the last five years. Cause-related marketing (CRM) is on the increase and may provide a long-term survival strategy for charities.⁵⁹ Donor behaviour is becoming more complex with donors more demanding of greater transparency and of more information on financial accountability.⁶⁰ The in-depth interviews also confirmed that the increasing number

of charities in the sector were putting pressure on the donor's dollar, highlighting the need for greater differentiation between charities. Charities need to assess the resilience of their organisations to a changing and more complex environment and, if necessary adopt an alternative strategic response, such as brand orientation. Hence, the following research proposition is formulated:

P₅ The greater the degree of environmental change, the more likely the adoption of brand orientation.

Brand orientation dimensions

The academic literature and in-depth interviews suggest brand orientation encompasses four conceptually distinct dimensions. However, it is not yet clear whether these dimensions are interconnected or whether each dimension represents a distinct component. Hence the following propositions may be formulated:

P₆ Although brand orientation is conceptualised as consisting of four distinct components, these may be combined into a single factor, a general factor of brand orientation.

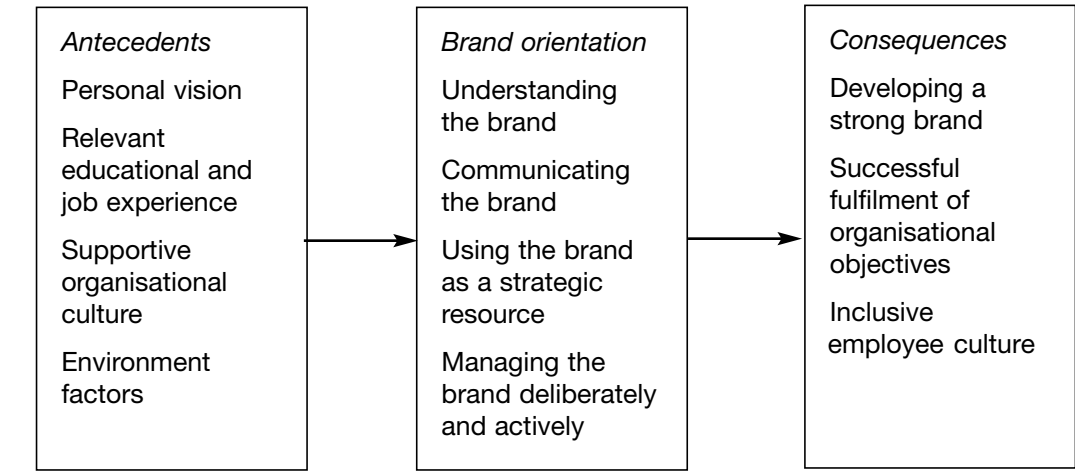
P₇ Brand orientation consists of four independent and conceptually distinct dimensions.

Brand consequences

Three factors emerged from the academic literature and the in-depth interviews as consequences of brand orientation. These were:

- the development of a strong brand
- the successful fulfilment of organisational objectives
- an inclusive employee culture.

Figure 2 The brand orientation construct



The development of a strong brand

Saxton⁶¹ argues that strong brands come from strong beliefs (values) and this is supported by case study reports such as Crisis,⁶² The Children’s Society,⁶³ and Barnardo’s.⁶⁴ Clarifying a charity’s brand values is a vital step in building a strong brand⁶⁵ and one that may help differentiate charities operating within the same sector. The in-depth interviews also endorsed the importance of understanding the values of the brand and thereafter their clear and consistent communication. Only then can donors perceive the kind of ‘fit’ that exists between their values and those of the charity which enables them to support those whose values most closely match their own. Hence, the following research proposition may be formulated:

P₈ Strong brands are more likely to result from brand-oriented charities.

Successful fulfilment of organisation objectives

Using the brand as a strategic resource is being increasingly adopted by the charity sector,⁶⁶ mirroring its rather longer estab-

lishment in the for-profit sector.^{67–69} As such it may be used to fulfil a variety of organisational objectives by capturing the essence of what the charity does and the values it represents. Hence, the following research proposition may be formulated:

P₉ The greater the level of brand orientation, the greater the likelihood of fulfilling organisational objectives.

Inclusive employee culture

The academic literature emphasises the importance of ‘taking employees with you’ when successfully branding or re-branding a charity organisation.^{70,71} Additionally, the in-depth interviews confirmed the importance of involving employees both in the initial brand development process and the subsequent brand launch or re-launch. Usually this took the form of staff meetings, training seminars and, sometimes, road-shows to the charity’s regional affiliates. Hence, the following research proposition may be formulated:

P₁₀ The greater the level of brand orientation, the more likely the achievement of staff involvement.

Thus the brand orientation construct with antecedents and consequences, as described above, may be illustrated as shown in Figure 2.

The ten research propositions identified above fit the broad framework of brand orientation as shown in Figure 2. Nevertheless, these propositions are not finite in number. Opportunities exist for extending the research agenda by adding further antecedents or consequences of brand orientation, which in turn will increase opportunities for further research propositions.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

The paper explores the domain of the brand orientation construct. It provides a working definition of the construct with antecedents which may increase or diminish levels of brand orientation and consequences which may result from its adoption. The paper puts forward a number of research propositions which constitute a framework for discussion and a research agenda for the charity sector. For instance, questions might be asked on how much understanding charity employees have of the specific values their charity represents (brand orientation construct), how much training is directed to achieve that understanding (antecedent) and the extent to which subsequent employee understanding leads to the development of a stronger brand (consequence). Alternatively, questions might be posed on how actively and deliberately the charity brand is being managed (brand orientation construct), how much this is driven by personal vision (antecedent), and whether this results in the more successful fulfilment of organisational objectives (consequence). In addition, a suitable measure of brand orientation needs to be developed in order to test the construct empirically. Item statements

which are thought to reflect the brand orientation construct will need to be generated and then correlated against a suitable validation scale.

Three further points also need to be addressed. First, the financial implications of building and sustaining a charity brand require considerable time and financial resources which inevitably means that finances will be diverted from service provision. Therefore, the introduction and adoption of brand orientation in charities may only be perceived as a benefit if the positive consequences exceed the costs of implementation, which is arguably of greater significance to smaller charities. Secondly, for the larger charities, particularly those which already operate at a global level, for instance, Oxfam, the Red Cross and Save the Children, transforming a global organisation into a global brand may help reduce the inevitable tensions that result from merging national charities into global charities. By making the brand an intellectual and behavioural priority for all national affiliates, a greater sense of oneness and intra-organisational co-operation might be achieved. Thirdly, it is worth noting the particular appropriateness of brand orientation to the charity sector. By its very nature, branding is a medium- to long-term process. Some of the most successful brands in the for-profit sector are more than 100 years old, a result of years of strategic development and sustained levels of financial investment.⁷² Charities generally have far more complex organisational aims than commercial enterprises, for instance, 'alleviating world hunger' rather than selling 10 per cent more cars. They are also less subject to the short-term pressures of satisfying shareholder demands for the City or Wall Street. Charities can, therefore, 'afford' to take a longer-term perspective which places them in a good position to develop a brand-oriented ap-

proach in their thinking and managerial practices.

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